

CONCEPT & TECHNICAL BRIEFING · PHASE 1 DIRECTION LOCKED

THIRD-PERSON SPACE SURVIVAL

Space*Survival*

How long can I survive, how strong can I make my build, and can I beat my previous run?

UNREAL ENGINE 5 WINDOWS / STEAM SINGLE-PLAYER 10-WAVE VERTICAL SLICE

ARROWS OR SPACE TO ADVANCE · G FOR OVERVIEW

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE



Survive an unpredictable universe long enough to build an increasingly capable spacecraft, knowing that eventually the universe will overwhelm you.

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

SpaceSurvival is not a sequence of asteroid levels, arenas, or missions. It is one uninterrupted journey through increasingly hostile space. Asteroids arrive. Enemy ships interfere. A storm develops. A gravity well changes the flight envelope. The player survives, collects credits, finds opportunities, upgrades the ship, and keeps moving.

Survive

Stay alive through overlapping pressure.

Build

Spend credits on a ship that is always almost not enough.

Repeat

Highest wave reached is the prestige number.



IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

02 / PILOT
03/18

02 / PILOT

Acornaut is the face of the run.

Acornaut is visibly piloting during gameplay. The head, body and tail silhouette stay readable in the canopy, but the spacecraft remains the dominant gameplay object. In hangars, stations and cinematics, the character steps forward.

Hybrid direction

Realistic materials on a stylized creature. Not chibi. Not a mascot sticker.

Light personality

Short reactions to critical damage, close calls, elites, rare rewards, station arrival. No chatter.

Station presence

Walk, run, interact. Compact third-person hubs, no combat or platforming.

Asset rule

A high-quality rigged source should be integrated rather than recreated.



IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

STARTER CHASSIS

Acorn hull

Arcade responsiveness with spacecraft weight. Strong forward momentum. The player progresses through space rather than parking in it.

04 / 18

03 / CRAFT

Two ships prove playstyle, not autopilot.

Early ships launch with one starting weapon. The first unlockable ship is faster and more agile, with slightly lower starting hull — a different feel, not a free win. No unlock should turn Waves 1–20 into a cruise.



Unlockable interceptor: higher base speed, stronger maneuvering, quicker response, thinner hull.



Everything answers one question.

Stay alive. The rest of the design is how pressure, power and surprise are delivered without breaking that sentence.

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

01

Continuous survival

The player is always doing one thing: stay alive. Waves organize difficulty, but they must not interrupt the illusion of a single journey through hostile space.

03

Build progression

A Wave 1 ship becomes dangerously underpowered. The player races both the universe and their own upgrade curve.

02

Escalating pressure

Later waves get harder through speed, density, force, new families, smarter combinations and shorter reaction windows — not enormous health pools.

04

Unpredictable, fair

The player should not know the next combination. The Director still forbids impossible stacks, unreadable overload, and spawns on the player. Brutal sometimes. Unfair rarely.



05 / RUN STRUCTURE

A loop with no ending, and a cadence you can feel.

Survival, credits, upgrades, increasing danger, fifth-wave climax, station, launch. Highest wave reached is the number players compare. Death returns Acornaut to a compact home hangar.

00 Hangar

Choose unlocked ship and one starting weapon. Launch.

02 Breathe

Pressure drops for a few seconds — never more than ~20s. Credits, signals, foreshadowing.

04 Station

Dock, walk, repair, upgrade, contract, save, relaunch. 1–3 minutes.

01 Survive

Duration-based waves. No countdown. No kill quota. Keep flying.

03 Climax

Every fifth wave is a guaranteed set-piece. Wave 5, 10, 15...

05 Harder

Repeat until hull hits zero. There is no final wave.



IDENTITY
EXPERIENCE
SYSTEMS
PHASE 1
CLOSE

06 / FEEL
07/18

06 / FLIGHT

Arcade hands. Spacecraft weight.

Responsive enough to survive fast asteroid sequences. Heavy enough to feel banking, momentum and consequence. Not a cursor. Not a simulator. Same flight model in traversal, combat and anomalies — the environment changes how you use it, not which mode you are in.

- PITCH
- YAW
- BANK
- THROTTLE
- BOOST
- PARTIAL BRAKE
- DIRECTIONAL DODGE
- INERTIA

Boost
Rechargeable meter. Drains while active. Regenerates on its own. Upgrades later improve capacity and recharge.

Brake
Meaningful deceleration, never a full stop. Heat builds. Continuous braking overheats the system. You cannot crawl through high-speed fields.

Dodge
A sharp directional burst. No invulnerability frames. Dodging into a rock still hurts.



IDENTITY
EXPERIENCE
SYSTEMS
WAVE 1
CLOSE

07 / SURVIVAL DIRECTOR

Same wave number. Different universe.

Each wave receives a hidden pressure budget. The Director spends it across density, velocity, enemies, environment, visibility, overlap, elites and reaction windows. Two Wave 7s can be equally hard and feel nothing alike. Later waves do not inflate health — they unlock a larger possibility space.

WAVE 7 - A

WAVE 7 - B

Asteroids

Enemies

Weather

Overlap

Reaction

Persistence is allowed: storms, nebulae, gravity, wreckage and pursuit can cross wave boundaries. The universe does not reset on a chime.

Hazards with reputations, not a biome menu.

Architecture must accept the full environmental library later without rewriting the Director. Phase 1 ships exactly these four. Regions are visual; gameplay composition stays with the Director.

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE



Asteroids

Small debris can be destroyed. Medium rocks break with enough firepower — sometimes into worse debris, sometimes into credits. Massive bodies are geometry. Shoot or avoid is a real decision.



Wreckage

Torn hulls and industrial corridors. Salvage sits off the safest line. Optional cache events pull the player into denser wreckage for a meaningful reward.





09 / COMBAT

Weapons are survival tools, not a mode switch.

Dodge, shoot, evade, collect, survive — without the game changing genre. Hybrid aiming: manual always, soft-lock on nearby valid targets, more assistance at high speed, never fully automatic.

ARCHETYPE

Pursuer

Closes distance and applies direct pressure.

ARCHETYPE

Flanker

Wider approach. Splits attention.

WEAPON

Rapid Laser

Fast, forgiving. Fighters and small debris.

WEAPON

Heavy Cannon

Slow, heavy. Medium asteroids and denser targets.

Difficulty scales through behavior, coordination, speed and overlap — a fighter remains a fighter. Elites exist; boss arenas do not.



Two layers. Very different psychology.

Damage is mostly subtractive, not spin-out. Late impacts against an under-upgraded ship can add deflection, momentum loss and rare subsystem impairment — Thrusters IV acting like II until repaired, never a lost purchase.

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

EXPENDABLE

Shield

- Drains first.
- Does not regenerate on its own.
- Rare pickups, station repair, upgrades for capacity.
- Valuable enough that players leave the safe line to take them.

RECOVERABLE

Hull

- Can regenerate to 100%.
- Out of danger: after a delay, recovery is relatively fast.
- In danger: possible, but much slower. Fresh hits interrupt it.
- Hull reaches zero → the run ends.

- Kinetic** · Damage, possible knockback
- Energy** · Heavier shield pressure
- Electrical** · Shield disruption, brief interference
- Gravity** · Flight distortion
- Thermal** · Heat or short damage-over-time



11 / BUILD

Spend on purpose. Starve a little.

Five purchased tracks, tiers I–V. Gating is soft — a skilled pilot can outfly an under-upgraded ship. A competent run funds about two or three meaningful purchases per major station. Play safe and live longer, or take risks and power up faster.

- 01 **Hull** Keeps later impacts survivable.
- 02 **Shield** Expendable layer. No passive regen.
- 03 **Engine** Acceleration, forward authority, movement pressure.
- 04 **Thrusters** Maneuverability and response.
- 05 **Weapon** Fighters, debris, medium rocks.

Vector Thrusters

Lateral and vertical authority under hazard pressure.

Overdrive Cooling

Boost and brake heat. Emergency sustained maneuvering.

Utilities come from events, depots and stations — never as surprise pickups in a rock storm. No inventory system in Phase 1.



12 / EVERY FIFTH WAVE

Stations are places, not pause menus.

Compact 3D hubs, roughly one to three minutes. Diegetic consoles: repair, upgrades, contracts, save, vendor, launch. Lived-in with NPCs, servicing, announcements and faction flavor — flavor, not diplomacy. Save is suspend/resume only. Dying later still ends the run; you cannot reload the station after death.

1. APPROACH MANUALLY
2. SAFE DOCKING CORRIDOR
3. LANDING ASSISTANCE
4. LAND
5. EXIT AS ACORNAUT
6. SERVICES
7. LAUNCH INTO THE NEXT BLOCK

Guaranteed: hull, shield, engine, thrusters, weapon, repair, Save & Quit, contracts, relaunch.



IDENTITY
EXPERIENCE
SYSTEMS
PHASE 1
CLOSE

Nothing important is forced on you mid-weave.

Events announce themselves with a HUD marker, label, range and a clear interaction point. Approach is not commitment. Acceptance is explicit. Rewards scale with danger: utilities and rare weapon replacements.

EVENT

Salvage cache

A dangerous diversion through wreckage for a meaningful haul.

EVENT

Distress / combat

Optional fight. Higher-quality reward.

CONTRACT

Difficulty modifier

A handicap — reduced shields, for example — for increased reward.

CONTRACT

Objective

Destroy N enemies or collect a resource before the next station.

Phase 1 guarantees exactly one mobile depot so the merchant beat can be evaluated. It offers a random subset of core upgrades and unusual deals. It does not replace stations.



IDENTITY
EXPERIENCE
SYSTEMS
PHASE 1
CLOSE

Unlock possibilities. Never trivialize the run.

Death strips run upgrades. Account XP, ships, weapons, cosmetics and starting options persist. Wave progression supplies reliable XP; strong play accelerates it. Prestige is highest wave reached. Score is a secondary composite of kills, contracts, salvage, elites and risk.

Phase 1 unlock A

Second starting weapon — Rapid Laser or Heavy Cannon as a choice, not a loadout screen full of toys.

Phase 1 unlock B

Second spacecraft: faster, more agile, slightly less hull. A different pilot, not a better one for free.

After death: XP, unlocks, hangar, next launch. Station saves never become a retry-from-checkpoint exploit.

Ten waves. Two climaxes. Two stations.

Near-alpha quality, not a gray box. The slice must make someone who dies on Wave 8 want to launch again.

- IDENTITY
- EXPERIENCE
- SYSTEMS
- PHASE 1
- CLOSE

WAVES 1–4	Escalating survival. Teach steering, boost, brake, dodge, then weapons, then enemies — through play, not a lecture.
WAVE 5	Authored climax. Wormhole pull, then hostile combat, then the first major station.
STATION 1	Full repair, five upgrade paths, contracts, Save & Quit, launch, 1–2 NPC beats, ship servicing, a side interaction.
WAVES 6–9	Director toolkit expands. Overlaps get meaner.
WAVE 10	Compound climax: gravity anomaly + asteroid storm + enemy pressure. Chaotic, fair, readable.
STATION 2	The cadence repeats. The loop is proven.



Wave 5 — the wormhole does not feel like a loading screen.

Hybrid look. Hybrid code. PC-first.

IDENTITY

EXPERIENCE

SYSTEMS

PHASE 1

CLOSE

VISUAL

Hybrid

Realistic materials, cinematic lighting, high-end space VFX, readable silhouettes. When realism fights readability, readability wins. Custom identity assets; licensed dressing normalized so the game never looks like an asset pack.

UNREAL 5

C++ / data

C++ owns flight, Director, waves, damage, boost, brake, dodge, run state, saves, upgrades, events, contracts. Blueprints and data assets own tuning, chunks, pickups, VFX and audio hooks.

TARGET

60 / 120+

60 FPS minimum acceptable. Architecture should let capable hardware hold 120+. Simulation is frame-rate independent. Keyboard and mouse, and controller, expose the same verbs. Offline-first. No networking in Phase 1.

HUD, camera, audio

Tight chase camera, modest pullback at speed. Moderate HUD: wave, hull, shield, boost, weapon, credits, soft-lock. Adaptive music that layers with pressure and strips back in the breathe window. Cinematic world sound, arcade-readable rewards.

Explicitly not Phase 1

Multiplayer, Steamworks, cloud saves, leaderboards, faction reputation, inventory, the full hazard and enemy libraries, extra weapons, extra stations, challenge modes. If the slice finishes early, polish — do not expand.

Does dying make you launch again?

The comparable is not an asteroid arcade and not a hard sim. It is the psychological loop of wave survival — Zombies, but the arena is an endless, changing universe, and the build is a spacecraft you can feel in your hands.

Fair brutality

The Director can hurt you. It should almost never cheat.

Build hunger

Credits, stations and risks make the next upgrade feel earned, not dropped.

Prestige

Highest wave is instantly understood. Everything else is flavor on the grave stone.

Phase 1 succeeds when unpredictable survival, ship handling, economy, stations and unlocks already create that loop — before the rest of the universe exists.

IDENTITY
EXPERIENCE
SYSTEMS
PHASE 1
CLOSE

